Other Kinds of Coaching

How coaching in organisations compares with systemic coaching and sports coaching, and what each one contributes to the way a workplace coach works.

Three kinds of coaching

Two other prominent kinds of coaching are systemic coaching and sports coaching. Coaching in organisations, whether by a leader, an internal coach or an external coach, borrows from both. There are similarities between all three, but also clear differences.

Systemic coaching

A **systemic coach** works with the system. The information, interpretations, goals and actions all come from the coachee, and the coach facilitates discovery through conversation. They ask neutral, open-ended questions related to keywords that come up in the discussion, for example: "Tell me more about your time there?" or "How did the others react to this piece of news?"

Coaching in organisations borrows a lot from systemic coaching. The difference is that a systemic coach does not steer, while a coach inside an organisation usually works towards a goal agreed with a sponsor, for example helping a team collaborate better or make decisions faster. Both usually have a sponsor and have been engaged to achieve something. A systemic coach, however, tries not to bring their own thoughts and ideas into the conversation, while a workplace coach may role-model new behaviour and introduce new practices.

Sports coaching

A workplace coach also works in some ways like a **sports coach**. Like sports coaches, many workplace coaches gained practical experience in their field before they started coaching, and both should work towards a clear goal.

However, workplace coaches are often given something vague to work on, such as "My team isn't meeting its goals". To work effectively, they first need to observe the situation or assess it quickly, form some hypotheses and agree the goal with their sponsor. Sports coaches, in contrast, set goals and targets for their team and are much more directive, which can include removing players who do not perform.

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What this means for your own coaching

Experienced coaches are aware of these differences and move between them deliberately. They take the neutral, open questioning of systemic coaching as their default, and they borrow the clarity of goals from sports coaching. Coaching in an organisation also requires activities other than coaching, such as teaching or advising. The resource on coaching stances describes them.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/coaching-skills/other-kinds-of-coaching